



Full throttle for Trump’s promised upheaval

Gabbard staff sought to limit fallout of Assad meetings

BY JON SWAINE
AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

Staffers for Rep. Tulsi Gabbard were wrestling with a question: Had she really met with the authoritarian leader of Syria for almost three hours?

It was Feb. 5, 2017, and the Hawaii Democrat — fresh from a trip to the pariah state that left Washington stunned — had circulated a timeline of her activities to help her staff prepare a report for the House Ethics Committee, according to a trove of documents from her office reviewed by The Washington Post. The committee requires detailed post-trip accounts of official travel, and Gabbard’s was due the next day.

The timeline, which has not been previously reported, said that Gabbard and Bashar al-Assad met at 12:15 p.m. on Jan. 16, 2017, and that her next appointment was with Assad’s wife at 3 p.m.

Gabbard’s deputy chief of staff replied that the Assad meeting seemed “rather long” and asked if any “formalities” could be broken out to “cut down on the time that it appears you two sat and talked.” Her press secretary asked if the Assad meeting could be grouped with encounters with other dignitaries so it would “appear more like” one in a series of “protocol meetings.” The report Gabbard eventually submitted to Congress said that the meeting with Assad lasted 90 minutes, and that the meeting with his wife began at

SEE GABBARD ON A9

Pardons: Biden’s and Trump’s acts redefine the power, experts say. **A2**

Springfield, Ohio: Haitians grapple with a wave of anxiety. **A7**

Federal workforce: Trump again moves to strip protections. **A8**



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST



ALLISON ROBERT FOR THE WASHINGTON POST



DEMETRIUS FREEMAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP: President Donald Trump walks into the Roosevelt Room on Tuesday. Rep. Elise M. Stefanik (R-New York) testifies at her hearing for U.N. ambassador. Stewart Rhodes, founder of the Oath Keepers, fields questions in D.C. after his pardon.

2 EXTREMIST JAN. 6 LEADERS WALK FREE

Experts warn pardons could buoy fringe groups

BY SPENCER S. HSU,
ELLIE SILVERMAN
AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

President Donald Trump defended his decision to free all of roughly 1,600 Jan. 6 riot defendants on Tuesday as the leaders of two extremist groups who played outsize roles in the Capitol attack walked out of federal prisons after serving a fraction of their sentences for seditious conspiracy.

Speaking at a White House news conference in which he rolled out a new AI initiative, Trump called the conspirators’ sentences “ridiculous and excessive,” saying he pardoned “people that were treated unbelievably poorly.” The news conference — in which he also touched on issues as varied as cryptocurrency and the war in Ukraine — capped a second day in office in which he at times struggled to pivot attention away from the controversial clemency actions.

Counterterrorism experts say the pardons could further embolden fringe groups and hamper the Justice Department’s fight against political violence.

Proud Boys leader Enrique Tarrio was headed home to Miami from a Louisiana prison and expected to address the media Tuesday at the airport, his lawyer said, freed from the longest sentence in the riot — 22 years — for mobilizing his right-wing group as an “army” to keep Trump in power as Congress met to confirm the 2020

SEE EXTREMISTS ON A4

A plea for ‘mercy’: Bishop urges Trump to show compassion. **B1**

Fashion: Threads of dated and classic styles in inaugural attire. **C1**

Klete Keller: Pardoned Olympic swimmer expresses “regret.” **D1**

Bid to end birthright citizenship stirs wave of lawsuits

BY DAVID NAKAMURA
AND SILVIA FOSTER-FRAU

President Donald Trump’s executive order to end birthright citizenship faced a barrage of legal challenges Tuesday from a bevy of states and civil rights groups, signaling that the effort could be tied up in court and unlikely to take effect next month as planned.

A coalition of 18 states, including New Jersey, New York and California, filed a lawsuit in Massachusetts, saying the order violates the constitutional rights of thousands of children and impos-

es undue costs on local jurisdictions that would lose federal funding tied to Medicaid and children’s health insurance. The District of Columbia and city of San Francisco also joined that filing.

Other states — Arizona, Oregon, Illinois and Washington — filed a separate legal challenge Tuesday in Seattle. And the American Civil Liberties Union and Lawyers for Civil Rights filed lawsuits in New Hampshire and Massachusetts, respectively, on behalf of parents whose children would not be eligible for citizenship under Trump’s order.

“The Constitution could not be more clear: citizenship of children born in the United States does not depend on the citizenship of their parents,” New Jersey Gov. Phil Murphy (D) said in a statement. “That principle is fundamental to who we are as a nation and what it means to be an American.”

New York Attorney General Letitia James said Trump’s action “is not just unconstitutional, it is profoundly dangerous.”

Trump signed the executive order shortly after his inauguration Monday. Titled “Protecting

SEE BIRTHRIGHT ON A6

DOJ shake-up begins with key officials pried from posts

BY PERRY STEIN
AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

The Trump administration has removed and reassigned several top career officials in the Justice Department’s national security and criminal divisions, according to multiple people familiar with the matter, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss personnel matters.

Two of the people said that at least 15 experienced career staffers across several divisions were removed from their positions and reassigned, a sign that the

new president and his aides plan to carry out their promises to dramatically reshape the agency, including to focus more on immigration enforcement.

As a way to skirt legal protections afforded to career staffers, many of the officials were transferred to other positions inside Justice, where they would probably have less influence on the department’s big decisions, the people said. The officials will have to decide whether to stay in their new assignments or leave the agency.

The Justice Department declined to comment.

Trump and his allies have long attacked the Justice Department and accused it of unfairly targeting them, including during special counsel Robert S. Mueller III’s investigation of possible links between Trump’s 2016 campaign and Russia. The animosity escalated after Trump finished his first term, as the agency investigated both Trump’s alleged efforts to overturn the 2020 election results and his alleged mishandling of classified documents and obstruction of government efforts to retrieve them.

Among the people being re-

SEE OFFICIALS ON A4

Ex-spies say a Tysons casino would put U.S. secrets at risk

BY LAURA VOZZELLA
AND TEO ARMUS

RICHMOND — Forget what you’ve seen in every James Bond movie: Spies and casinos don’t mix. At least they shouldn’t mix, according to real-life agents fighting a proposed Fairfax County casino as a national security threat.

Home to CIA headquarters, the National Counterterrorism Center, the Office of the Director of National Intelligence, and countless supersecret defense and intelligence contractors, the D.C. suburb probably boasts

more security clearances than anywhere else in America, says a group of ex-spies, who warn in a letter to state and local officials that building a casino in Tysons could lead those secret-keepers astray.

“The proximity of a Tysons casino to a significant population of government, military, and contract officials with access to highly secretive government intelligence, diplomatic, and defense information will not only attract organized crime — casinos all ways do — but also adversarial intelligence services looking to

SEE CASINO ON A18



MICHAEL DEMOCKER/GETTY IMAGES

A rare winter scene in New Orleans

St. Louis Cathedral in the French Quarter is seen through the snow Tuesday. A storm that swept across the South brought snow and ice, crippling areas from Texas to the Carolinas.

Google rushed to sell AI tools to Israel in early days of war

BY GERRIT DE VYNCK

SAN FRANCISCO — Google employees have worked to provide Israel’s military with access to the company’s latest artificial intelligence technology from the early weeks of the Israel-Gaza war, according to documents obtained by The Washington Post.

The internal documents show Google directly assisting Israel’s Defense Ministry and the Israel Defense Forces, despite the company’s efforts to publicly distance itself from the country’s national security apparatus after employee protests against a cloud comput-

ing contract with Israel’s government.

Google fired more than 50 employees last year after they protested the contract, known as Nimbus, over fears it could see Google technology aid military and intelligence programs that have harmed Palestinians.

In the weeks after the Oct. 7, 2023, attack on Israel by Hamas militants, a Google employee in its cloud division escalated requests for increased access to the

SEE GOOGLE ON A18

West Bank: Israeli forces launch a major military operation. **A11**

IN THE NEWS

Israeli military chief resigns Citing his role in the “failure” of Oct. 7, 2023, the nation’s top general will step down amid tensions between the prime minister and army brass. **A11**

Maternal health A D.C. hospital program that goes beyond medicine to focus on patients’ social needs has shown promising results. **B1**

THE NATION

The Trump administration ousted the Coast Guard’s top officer. **A3**
Pete Hegseth’s former sister-in-law alleged in an affidavit that he behaved abusively toward his second wife. **A5**

THE WORLD

A fire in an upscale hotel at a popular ski resort in Turkey killed at least 76 people. **A10**
The Taliban released two Americans as part of a prisoner swap, their families said. **A12**

THE ECONOMY

Southern California Edison, suspected by many to be at fault in the Eaton Fire, is the latest utility to face a climate-induced crisis. **A13**
Democrats are moving to shield the Medicaid program from potential cuts under the Trump administration. **A14**

THE REGION

An agriculture teacher’s quest to evict vultures from the grounds of Fauquier High has been an educational journey. **B1**
Family and friends gathered to lay former D.C. drug kingpin Rayful Edmond III, 60, to rest. **B1**

OBITUARIES

Jules Feiffer, 95, was a Pulitzer Prize-winning cartoonist of acerbic wit with a flair for satire. **B1**

FOOD

Dried apples and dumplings star in a hearty Pennsylvania Dutch stew that can go savory or sweet and is ideal for winter. **E1**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A13
COMICS.....C7
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A15
TELEVISION.....C6
WORLD NEWS.....A10

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54104

